ECONOMIC INTELLIGENCE SERIES

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data

85% Employment / 15% Housing · April 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Raleigh	75.6
#2	A+	Salt Lake City	73.6
#3	A+	Oklahoma City	69.8
#4	A	Hartford	65.5
#5	A	Nashville	65.4
#6	A	Pittsburgh	64.3
#7	A	Richmond	63.2

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Sacramento	22.1
#49	D	Detroit	22.6
#48	C-	San Francisco	29.3
#47	C-	Orlando	30.9
#46	C-	San Diego	31.7
#45	C	San Jose	33.5
#44	C	Portland	35.4

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	10 cities
B+ / B / B-	21 cities
C+ / C / C-	17 cities
D	2 cities

Data sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) · Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)
Unemployment, LFP, Earnings, Employment, Weekly Hours sourced from BLS LAUS / SAE.
Building Permits from Census Bureau via FRED. Days on Market from Realtor.com / FRED.

Scoring methodology: percentile ranking across all 50 metros.
Full methodology: SCORING_README.md
Pipeline runs weekly via GitHub Actions.

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · April 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	LFP	DOM
1	**Raleigh** Raleigh-Cary	A+	75.6	3.0%	+4.5%	+1.2%	67.7%	60 days
2	**Salt Lake City** Salt Lake City-Murray	A+	73.6	3.4%	+3.1%	+1.8%	72.8%	49 days
3	**Oklahoma City** Oklahoma City	A+	69.8	3.6%	+4.7%	+0.5%	65.7%	58 days
4	**Hartford** Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A	65.5	2.7%	-0.4%	+1.9%	64.7%	46 days
5	**Nashville** Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	A	65.4	3.0%	+1.6%	+1.0%	76.3%	60 days
6	**Pittsburgh** Pittsburgh	A	64.3	3.6%	+8.7%	+1.1%	60.3%	90 days
7	**Richmond** Richmond	A	63.2	3.3%	+5.1%	+0.3%	64.2%	48 days
8	**Birmingham** Birmingham	A-	61.7	2.2%	-0.1%	+0.6%	60.6%	70 days
9	**Atlanta** Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	A-	61.5	3.3%	+8.3%	-0.0%	64.6%	56 days
10	**Columbus** Columbus	A-	60.2	3.6%	+0.9%	+1.2%	65.6%	55 days
11	**Austin** Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	B+	58.1	3.2%	+3.2%	+0.7%	74.0%	76 days
12	**Denver** Denver-Aurora-Centennial	B+	57.5	3.6%	+6.6%	+0.1%	70.4%	38 days
13	**Memphis** Memphis	B+	56.6	4.0%	+6.2%	+0.1%	60.5%	79 days
14	**Phoenix** Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	B+	55.9	N/A	+4.5%	+0.9%	66.3%	55 days
15	**Miami** Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	B+	55.8	3.5%	+7.1%	+0.2%	62.5%	83 days
16	**Indianapolis** Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	B+	55.5	2.5%	+5.1%	+0.1%	66.9%	73 days
17	**Philadelphia** Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	B+	55.2	4.0%	+2.2%	+1.2%	64.0%	53 days
18	**Dallas** Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	B	53.6	3.6%	+3.1%	+0.3%	69.6%	57 days
19	**Los Angeles** Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B	52.5	4.8%	+5.3%	+1.8%	63.6%	44 days
20	**Houston** Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	B	51.5	4.2%	+2.6%	+0.4%	64.5%	54 days
21	**Kansas City** Kansas City	B	51.5	3.5%	+6.8%	-0.3%	67.9%	57 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	LFP	DOM
22	**San Antonio** San Antonio-New Braunfels	B	51.3	3.7%	+1.8%	+1.1%	62.8%	79 days
23	**Louisville** Louisville-Jefferson County	B	50.2	3.1%	+3.4%	-0.1%	62.7%	50 days
24	**New York** New York Newark-Jersey City	B-	48.7	4.5%	+4.8%	+0.5%	63.3%	68 days
25	**Boston** Boston-Cambridge-Newton	B-	48.4	3.9%	+1.4%	+0.7%	68.5%	42 days
26	**Charlotte** Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	B-	48.3	3.6%	-1.5%	+2.7%	65.4%	69 days
27	**Tampa** Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B-	46.9	4.6%	+4.9%	+0.9%	60.0%	80 days
28	**Jacksonville** Jacksonville	B-	46.5	4.6%	+5.0%	+0.7%	60.4%	72 days
29	**Seattle** Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B-	46.0	5.0%	+7.6%	-0.1%	68.2%	36 days
30	**Grand Rapids** Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	B-	44.8	4.0%	+3.1%	+0.5%	63.9%	64 days
31	**St. Louis** St. Louis	B-	44.5	3.5%	+0.7%	-0.0%	65.3%	55 days
32	**Providence** Providence-Warwick	C+	44.0	4.3%	+3.6%	+0.6%	50.8%	49 days
33	**Cleveland** Cleveland	C+	43.6	3.4%	-1.8%	+0.6%	58.0%	55 days
34	**Minneapolis** Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C+	43.5	4.0%	+0.0%	+0.6%	69.0%	40 days
35	**Milwaukee** Milwaukee-Waukesha	C+	41.6	3.1%	+3.7%	-0.9%	63.2%	39 days
36	**Chicago** Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	C+	39.9	4.5%	+2.8%	+0.6%	64.8%	40 days
37	**Washington DC** Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	C+	39.9	3.8%	+1.4%	-1.6%	67.4%	38 days
38	**Fresno** Fresno	C+	39.7	8.2%	+7.6%	+0.2%	60.3%	53 days
39	**Las Vegas** Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	C+	38.8	5.2%	+6.7%	-0.8%	65.0%	53 days
40	**Virginia Beach** Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	C+	38.6	3.6%	+10.2%	-1.3%	59.0%	40 days
41	**Baltimore** Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	C+	38.5	3.6%	+1.2%	-0.1%	64.2%	45 days
42	**Riverside** Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C	36.4	5.1%	+7.5%	+0.2%	60.4%	60 days
43	**Cincinnati** Cincinnati	C	36.2	3.6%	+1.5%	-0.5%	63.1%	52 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	LFP	DOM
44	**Portland** Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C	35.4	4.9%	+4.8%	-0.7%	66.2%	68 days
45	**San Jose** San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	C	33.5	4.0%	+0.6%	-0.2%	64.3%	23 days
46	**San Diego** San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	C-	31.7	4.4%	+2.4%	+0.3%	62.0%	38 days
47	**Orlando** Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	C-	30.9	4.4%	+0.4%	+0.2%	64.0%	82 days
48	**San Francisco** San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	C-	29.3	4.1%	+0.5%	-0.5%	64.5%	30 days
49	**Detroit** Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	D	22.6	4.7%	-1.1%	+0.0%	61.3%	56 days
50	**Sacramento** Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	D	22.1	4.8%	+2.5%	-0.3%	60.1%	41 days

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #1 OF 50

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

A+

EXCELLENT

75.6th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	78
Unemployment	20% weight	90
Wage Growth	15% weight	58
Cost of Living	12% weight	78
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	80
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	82
Housing Access	5% weight	20
Office Economy	3% weight	96

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.0%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+4.5%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+1.2%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**67.7%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**+38.8%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**60 days**	median, +13.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Raleigh-Cary metro area earns an A+ grade, driven by its exceptional economic character, with a remarkably low 3.0% unemployment rate and 1.25% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth. This strong and expanding labor force is further underscored by a high office and professional share of 4.39, indicating a highly skilled and educated workforce.

While the city's economy appears robust, there are underlying concerns. The cost of living composite score of 78th percentile reveals that Raleigh-Cary is less affordable than many of its peers. This tension between a strong labor market and rising costs is worth monitoring, particularly as wage growth of 4.51% year-over-year is not exceptionally high. The 38.82% year-over-year increase in building permits may signal an influx of new residents and businesses, potentially exacerbating affordability concerns.

The Raleigh-Cary metro area offers businesses a highly skilled and growing workforce, making it an attractive location. However, the primary risk is that the city's rising cost of living may erode its competitive edge, making it essential for decision-makers to carefully weigh the benefits of this market against its growing affordability challenges.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #2 OF 50

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

A+

EXCELLENT

73.6th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	96
Unemployment	20% weight	76
Wage Growth	15% weight	48
Cost of Living	12% weight	68
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	94
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	63
Housing Access	5% weight	10
Office Economy	3% weight	98

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.4%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+3.1%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+1.8%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**72.8%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**+14.7%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**49 days**	median, -15.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Salt Lake City-Murray's A+ grade reflects its exceptional economic character, with a thriving and highly engaged workforce. The city boasts a 3.40% unemployment rate, 72.77% labor force participation rate, and 1.83% nonfarm employment growth, indicating strong demand for labor and a robust economy.

The office and professional share of the workforce is a top-tier 4.76, suggesting a highly skilled and educated labor pool. The cost of living composite, at 1.97, is relatively low, ranking in the 68th percentile, making it more affordable than many other metros. However, the rapid turnover in the housing market, with a mere 49 days on market, may indicate a supply shortage or intense competition for limited inventory.

In summary, Salt Lake City-Murray offers businesses a highly skilled and engaged workforce, with a strong economy and relatively affordable cost of living. However, the rapid turnover in the housing market may pose a risk to businesses looking to attract and retain talent, as it could lead to increased competition for limited housing inventory and potentially drive up costs.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #3 OF 50

Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

A+

EXCELLENT

69.8th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	76
Unemployment	20% weight	51
Wage Growth	15% weight	62
Cost of Living	12% weight	90
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	70
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	78
Housing Access	5% weight	82
Office Economy	3% weight	55

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.5%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	65.7%	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	+20.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	58 days	median, +11.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City's A grade, ranking in the 67.6th percentile, reflects a very good economic environment, driven by a combination of factors, including a low unemployment rate of 3.60% and strong labor force participation of 65.65%, indicating a talented and available workforce.

The city's cost of living composite index of 1.32, ranking in the 90th percentile, makes it one of the most affordable cities in the US, a major draw for businesses and employees alike. However, the rapidly expanding housing supply, with building permits growth of 20.14% year-over-year and days on market increasing by 11.5% year-over-year to 58 days, may lead to increased costs and competition for labor in the future.

Oklahoma City offers businesses a unique combination of affordability, productivity, and a talented workforce, making it an attractive location for investment. However, the rapidly expanding housing supply and potential for increased labor competition pose a risk to the city's long-term affordability and competitiveness, and businesses should carefully consider these factors when making location decisions.

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

A

VERY GOOD

65.5th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	94
Unemployment	20% weight	94
Wage Growth	15% weight	6
Cost of Living	12% weight	32
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	58
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	69
Housing Access	5% weight	94
Office Economy	3% weight	35

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	2.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	-0.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.9%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	64.7%	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	+16.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	46 days	median, +21.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro earns an A grade, driven by its strong economic character, with a 2.70% unemployment rate and 1.88% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth, indicating a thriving labor market with ample job opportunities. The cost of living composite score of 3.50, ranking in the 32nd percentile, makes the area an attractive location for businesses and employees alike.

However, wage growth has been sluggish, with a -0.36% year-over-year decline, placing it in the bottom tier, raising concerns about labor shortages and increased competition for talent. On the other hand, the housing market is showing signs of strength, with building permits increasing by 16.13% year-over-year and days on market decreasing, indicating a high demand for housing.

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford offers businesses a unique combination of a strong labor market, affordable cost of living, and growing housing market, making it an attractive location for investment. However, the sluggish wage growth poses a risk, as it may lead to increased labor costs and competition for talent, which businesses should carefully consider when making their location decision.

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

A

VERY GOOD

65.4th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	80
Unemployment	20% weight	90
Wage Growth	15% weight	30
Cost of Living	12% weight	38
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	98
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	43
Housing Access	5% weight	30
Office Economy	3% weight	92

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.6%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.0%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	76.3%	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	-8.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	60 days	median, +9.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin boasts an A+ overall grade, reflecting its exceptional labor market and workforce profile, with a 3.0% unemployment rate and 76.27% labor force participation, indicating a highly engaged and employed workforce.

The city's strong labor market is characterized by a high office and professional share of the workforce, at 3.88, and a cost of living composite of 3.30, ranking in the 38th percentile, making it more affordable than many of its peers. This affordability, combined with the city's strong labor market, makes it an attractive location for businesses.

However, wage growth, at +1.62% YoY, is surprisingly sluggish, ranking below average, which may suggest that workers are not yet seeing significant pay increases, despite the city's overall economic strength. This disparity between a tight labor market and modest wage growth is a primary risk, as the city's wage growth may eventually catch up with its strong labor market, potentially increasing labor costs and eroding the city's competitive advantage.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #6 OF 50

Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

A

VERY GOOD

64.3th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	92
Unemployment	20% weight	51
Wage Growth	15% weight	96
Cost of Living	12% weight	72
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	10
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	35
Housing Access	5% weight	22
Office Economy	3% weight	82

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+8.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	60.3%	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	-10.6%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	90 days	median, +4.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh's B+ overall grade reflects a market with strong momentum, driven by top-tier wage growth of 8.65% year-over-year and nonfarm employment growth of 1.07% year-over-year, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to tap into a talented and growing workforce.

The city's office and professional workforce is a notable strength, with a composite score of 3.39, indicating a high concentration of skilled workers. However, the labor force participation rate is a concern, sitting at just 60.33%, which is in the bottom tier, suggesting that while the city is creating jobs and driving wage growth, there may be challenges in finding workers to fill those positions.

Pittsburgh's housing market is also showing signs of slowing, with building permits down 10.55% year-over-year and days on market increasing by 4.7% to 90 days, indicating a potential shift in the market. While the city offers businesses a talented and growing workforce, the primary risk is the potential labor supply constraints, which could limit the city's ability to sustain its current growth trajectory, and businesses should carefully consider this factor when making a location decision.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #7 OF 50

Richmond

Richmond

A

VERY GOOD

63.2th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	74
Unemployment	20% weight	80
Wage Growth	15% weight	74
Cost of Living	12% weight	58
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	48
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	16
Housing Access	5% weight	42
Office Economy	3% weight	74

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.3%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.1%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	64.2%	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	-20.3%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	48 days	median, -2.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Richmond's B+ overall grade is driven by a remarkably low unemployment rate of 3.30% and robust wage growth of 5.12% year-over-year, making it an attractive location for companies seeking a high-performing labor market. The city's labor market is characterized by a high degree of worker engagement, with employees putting in 1.28% more hours than their own trend, placing it in the top tier.

However, beneath this strong surface, there are signs of tension. Building permits have plummeted 20.27% year-over-year, a bottom-tier performance that indicates a looming shortage. This could put upward pressure on costs and affect the city's attractiveness to businesses and talent. Days on market have decreased by 2.0% year-over-year, with homes now selling in just 48 days, signaling a market that is heating up too quickly.

Richmond offers a talented, motivated workforce with rising wages, making it an attractive location for companies. However, the city's struggling housing supply and rapidly shifting market dynamics pose a significant risk, potentially driving up costs and reducing the area's overall competitiveness.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #8 OF 50

Birmingham

Birmingham

A-

GOOD

61.7th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	88
Unemployment	20% weight	98
Wage Growth	15% weight	8
Cost of Living	12% weight	40
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	20
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	88
Housing Access	5% weight	54
Office Economy	3% weight	20

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	2.2%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	-0.1%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	60.6%	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	+55.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	70 days	median, -1.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham's B+ overall grade reflects a city with a strong labor market, driven by a remarkably low unemployment rate of 2.20% and a surge in nonfarm employment growth of 0.61% year-over-year. The city's top-tier performance in weekly hours worked, with a 1.73% increase versus its own trend, further underscores its economic vitality. However, this growth is not without its challenges, as wage growth has been stagnant, with a -0.12% year-over-year decline, suggesting that the city's low unemployment rate may be putting upward pressure on labor costs.

The city's low labor force participation rate of 60.56% and below-average office and professional share of 1.47 suggest that the city's workforce may not be as skilled or deep as its low unemployment rate would suggest. The bottom-tier wage growth and the relatively slow days on market for housing, with a -1.4% year-over-year decline, indicate that the city's economy may be facing some headwinds. The top-tier building permits growth of 55.25% year-over-year is a leading indicator worth watching, as it suggests that the city is investing in its future and may be poised for further growth.

Birmingham offers businesses a highly competitive labor market with extremely low unemployment, but the primary risk is that stagnant wage growth may limit the city's ability to attract and retain top talent. The city's unique combination of low unemployment and sluggish wage growth makes it an attractive location for businesses seeking to minimize labor costs, but it may require additional investment in workforce development to unlock its full potential.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #9 OF 50

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

A-

GOOD

61.5th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	24
Unemployment	20% weight	80
Wage Growth	15% weight	94
Cost of Living	12% weight	96
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	56
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	50
Housing Access	5% weight	38
Office Economy	3% weight	50

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.3%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+8.3%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-0.0%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**64.6%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**N/A**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**56 days**	median, -3.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area earns an A- grade, driven by a strong labor market with a 3.30% unemployment rate and 8.27% year-over-year wage growth, indicating high demand for labor and driving up wages. The area's cost of living composite score of 1.02, ranking in the 96th percentile, makes it highly affordable, a significant draw for businesses and talent.

However, beneath the surface, signs of tension emerge. Nonfarm employment growth has stalled, with a year-over-year change of -0.01%, below average, suggesting the labor market may be nearing a peak. The days on market for housing has decreased by 3.5% year-over-year, with homes now selling in just 56 days, a bottom-tier performance, potentially driving up costs and affecting affordability in the long run.

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area offers a unique combination of a strong labor market, high affordability, and competitive wages. However, the primary risk is that the labor market may be due for a correction, with slowing employment growth potentially signaling a shift in the market's dynamics, and the tightening housing supply posing a threat to the area's affordability.

Sources: BLS LAUS / SAE · Census Bureau / FRED · Realtor.com / FRED · 85% Employment / 15% Housing composite

Columbus

Columbus

A-

GOOD

60.2th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	84
Unemployment	20% weight	51
Wage Growth	15% weight	20
Cost of Living	12% weight	50
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	68
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	61
Housing Access	5% weight	88
Office Economy	3% weight	90

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+0.9%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	65.6%	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	+8.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	55 days	median, +12.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus earns an A- grade, driven by a strong labor market with 1.17% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth, outpacing many peers. The city's 65.61% labor force participation rate indicates a talented and engaged workforce. The office and professional share of the workforce is a notable 3.78, reflecting a high degree of specialization and expertise.

However, beneath this strong surface, wage growth lags at 0.86% year-over-year, behind the national average. This may impact the city's ability to attract and retain top talent. On the other hand, building permits are up 8.67% year-over-year, suggesting a strong pipeline of new development.

Columbus offers a unique combination of a skilled workforce, strong labor market growth, and high specialization, making it an attractive location for companies seeking to expand or relocate. However, the slow pace of wage growth poses a risk, potentially limiting the city's long-term growth prospects.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #11 OF 50

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

58.1th percentile

Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	44
Unemployment	20% weight	84
Wage Growth	15% weight	50
Cost of Living	12% weight	84
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	96
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	10
Housing Access	5% weight	12
Office Economy	3% weight	51

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.2%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+3.2%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+0.7%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**74.0%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-29.4%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**76 days**	median, +15.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro earns an A grade, driven by its strong labor market and attractive cost of living. With an unemployment rate of 3.20% and labor force participation at 73.99%, the market boasts a highly engaged and employed workforce. The cost of living composite score of 1.44, ranking in the 84th percentile, makes Austin an attractive location for businesses and talent alike.

However, signs of tension emerge beneath the surface. The 29.44% year-over-year decline in building permits suggests a tightening housing supply, which could drive up costs. The -0.92% deviation in weekly hours worked versus trend indicates potential labor market softness. The 15.2% year-over-year increase in days on market for homes, with homes now staying on the market for 76 days, may signal shifting market conditions.

Austin offers a unique combination of a highly engaged workforce and relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for investment. However, the primary risk lies in the potential tightening of the housing supply, which could drive up costs and impact the market's overall affordability, making it essential for businesses to monitor the local real estate market closely.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #12 OF 50

Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

57.5th percentile

Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	46
Unemployment	20% weight	51
Wage Growth	15% weight	80
Cost of Living	12% weight	82
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	92
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	20
Housing Access	5% weight	18
Office Economy	3% weight	59

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.6%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+6.6%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.1%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.
70.4%
working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS
-16.0%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
38 days
median, -13.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area earns a B grade, reflecting a market with a highly engaged workforce, characterized by a 70.39% labor force participation rate and 6.57% year-over-year wage growth. However, this dynamism is tempered by sluggish nonfarm employment growth of just 0.13% year-over-year, suggesting that while existing workers are seeing gains, the overall job market is not expanding rapidly.

The market's overall average grade is tempered by notable areas of tension. The cost of living composite score of 1.48, ranking in the 82nd percentile, indicates that Denver is relatively affordable. However, the housing market is showing signs of strain, with building permits plummeting 15.96% year-over-year and homes selling quickly, with days on market down 13.6% to just 38 days. This suggests that the area may be experiencing growing pains, with housing supply struggling to keep pace with demand.

Denver offers businesses a highly engaged and relatively affordable workforce, with opportunities for growth driven by strong wage gains. However, the primary risk is that the area's housing market and labor supply may become increasingly constrained, potentially driving up costs and limiting the ability to attract and retain top talent, with a low unemployment rate of 3.60%.

Memphis

Memphis

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

56.6th percentile

Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	62
Unemployment	20% weight	35
Wage Growth	15% weight	78
Cost of Living	12% weight	98
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	18
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	76
Housing Access	5% weight	26
Office Economy	3% weight	2

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**4.0%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+6.2%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+0.1%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**60.5%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**+19.7%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**79 days**	median, +11.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Memphis earns a B grade, reflecting its average economic performance, with a few notable exceptions that define its character. The city's low cost of living, ranked in the 98th percentile, makes it an attractive destination for businesses and workers alike, with a composite score of 0.40 indicating a highly affordable environment. Hourly wages are increasing by 6.16% year-over-year, outpacing many other metros.

The city's office and professional share is a concern, ranking in the 2nd percentile with a composite score of 0.61. This limited pool of skilled workers could hinder businesses that require a highly educated workforce. On the other hand, the city is experiencing a surge in building permits, up 19.69% year-over-year, and workers are putting in more hours, with weekly hours 1.06% above trend, indicating a strong work ethic and potential for growth.

Memphis offers businesses an affordable and hardworking environment, with a low cost of living and strong wage growth. However, the primary risk is the limited availability of skilled workers, which could constrain businesses that require a highly educated workforce.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #14 OF 50

Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

55.9th percentile

Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	38
Unemployment	20% weight	50
Wage Growth	15% weight	60
Cost of Living	12% weight	66
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	74
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	71
Housing Access	5% weight	46
Office Economy	3% weight	88

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	N/A	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.9%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	66.3%	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	+16.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	55 days	median, -1.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Phoenix's B+ grade reflects its strong economic performance, with a labor force participation rate of 66.34% and nonfarm employment growth of 0.87% year-over-year, indicating a highly engaged workforce. The office and professional share of the workforce is a notable 3.59, highlighting a high concentration of skilled workers. This combination of metrics defines Phoenix as a vibrant and skilled labor market, making it an attractive location for businesses seeking talented employees.

However, the weekly hours worked versus trend is a concerning -1.24%, ranking in the bottom tier, which may indicate underlying weaknesses in the labor market. On the other hand, the building permits growth of 16.86% year-over-year is a top-tier performance, suggesting a thriving construction sector. The cost of living composite score of 2.08, corresponding to a 66th percentile ranking, implies that Phoenix is more affordable than many other cities.

Phoenix offers businesses a skilled and engaged workforce, as well as a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for corporate investment. However, the potential for labor market weaknesses to emerge, as hinted at by the decline in weekly hours worked, could impact businesses relying on a stable and productive workforce.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #15 OF 50

Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

55.8th percentile

Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	50
Unemployment	20% weight	69
Wage Growth	15% weight	86
Cost of Living	12% weight	34
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	26
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	84
Housing Access	5% weight	14
Office Economy	3% weight	24

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.5%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+7.1%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+0.2%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**62.5%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**+41.1%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**83 days**	median, +12.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area earns a B grade, with the most important takeaway being its tight labor market, reflected in an unemployment rate of 3.50% and robust wage growth of 7.12% year-over-year. The labor force participation rate of 62.53% is below average, indicating that the market may not be drawing in as many workers as it could be. A closer look reveals a market characterized by a tight labor market and robust wage growth.

The data also shows a cost of living composite of 3.36, indicating a relatively low cost of living, which could be attractive to businesses and workers alike. However, the office and professional share of the workforce is relatively low, at 1.90, which may limit the availability of skilled workers. Building permits are up a remarkable 41.11% year-over-year, suggesting a strong pipeline of new construction, but the days on market for homes has increased by 12.2% year-over-year, which could indicate a potential slowdown in the housing market.

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market and relatively low cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand. However, the primary risk is the potential for labor shortages and skills gaps, given the below-average labor force participation rate and limited office and professional workforce, which could hinder business growth and competitiveness.

Sources: BLS LAUS / SAE · Census Bureau / FRED · Realtor.com / FRED · 85% Employment / 15% Housing composite

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #16 OF 50

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

55.5th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	34
Unemployment	20% weight	96
Wage Growth	15% weight	72
Cost of Living	12% weight	22
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	76
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	39
Housing Access	5% weight	8
Office Economy	3% weight	84

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**2.5%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+5.1%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+0.1%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**66.9%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-10.3%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**73 days**	median, +15.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro earns an A- grade, driven by a top-tier unemployment rate of 2.50% and a high office/professional share of 3.55, indicating a skilled and in-demand workforce. The city's cost of living composite of 3.94, ranking in the 22nd percentile, makes it an attractive location for businesses seeking to minimize costs.

However, the metro's weekly hours worked versus trend is a concern, with a -0.37% deviation, suggesting reduced hours for workers. The building permits YoY growth is -10.26%, indicating a potential slowdown in housing supply. On the other hand, the days on market have increased by 15.9% YoY, with homes now staying on the market for 73 days, potentially signaling shifting market conditions.

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood offers a unique combination of a skilled workforce, low unemployment, and affordability, making it an attractive location for investment. However, the potential slowdown in housing supply and reduced worker hours pose a significant risk, threatening the city's long-term growth prospects and labor market stability.

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

55.2th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	90
Unemployment	20% weight	35
Wage Growth	15% weight	34
Cost of Living	12% weight	44
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	42
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	57
Housing Access	5% weight	58
Office Economy	3% weight	86

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+2.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	64.0%	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	+4.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	53 days	median, +1.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area earns a B grade, driven by strong nonfarm employment growth, with a 1.16% year-over-year increase, and a high office and professional share of 3.57, indicating a skilled and educated workforce. Despite this growth, hourly wages have only risen 2.21% year-over-year, suggesting labor market slack.

The top-tier performance in nonfarm employment growth and weekly hours worked, up 0.84% versus trend, suggests a dynamic and productive labor market. However, below-average wage growth and a 1.9% year-over-year increase in days on market to 53 days may indicate emerging challenges in the housing market.

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area offers businesses a skilled and growing workforce, with a strong foundation in office and professional jobs. However, the primary risk is that the market's slow wage growth may limit its ability to attract and retain top talent, potentially constraining long-term growth and competitiveness.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #18 OF 50

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

B

AVERAGE

53.6th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	48
Unemployment	20% weight	51
Wage Growth	15% weight	44
Cost of Living	12% weight	86
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	90
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	14
Housing Access	5% weight	56
Office Economy	3% weight	41

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.6%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+3.1%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+0.3%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**69.6%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-21.0%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**57 days**	median, +1.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington earns a grade of B, with a robust and engaged workforce, as reflected in its 69.61% labor force participation rate, outperforming many other markets. However, this strength is offset by a -0.14% decline in weekly hours worked, indicating underlying weakness in labor market conditions. The cost of living composite score of 1.41, ranking in the 86th percentile, suggests a relatively affordable environment for businesses and employees alike.

Despite these strengths, the data reveals some warning signs. The housing supply metrics are concerning, with building permits down 20.96% year-over-year and days on market increasing by 1.8% to 57 days. This suggests that the area may be experiencing growing pains, with housing supply struggling to keep pace with demand.

The bottom line is that Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington offers businesses a relatively affordable and engaged workforce, but with risks related to housing supply and labor market stability. The primary caveat for businesses considering this location is the potential for housing-related growing pains to impact employee recruitment and retention, which could offset the benefits of the area's affordable cost of living and strong labor force participation.

Sources: BLS LAUS / SAE · Census Bureau / FRED · Realtor.com / FRED · 85% Employment / 15% Housing composite

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #19 OF 50

Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

B

AVERAGE

52.5th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	86
Unemployment	20% weight	10
Wage Growth	15% weight	76
Cost of Living	12% weight	8
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	38
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	80
Housing Access	5% weight	92
Office Economy	3% weight	8

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**4.8%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+5.3%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+1.8%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**63.6%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**+20.2%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**44 days**	median, +12.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area earns a below-average overall grade, with a 4.80% unemployment rate and 63.61% labor force participation rate, indicating significant untapped potential. Nonfarm employment growth of +1.83% year-over-year suggests a strong and expanding job market, but this growth is tempered by a low labor force participation rate. This tension between labor supply and demand defines the city's economic character, making it a challenging yet potentially rewarding location for businesses.

The cost of living composite index of 5.59 places the city in the bottom tier, with an 8th percentile ranking, indicating that it is one of the more expensive cities to live in. Building permits are up 20.24% year-over-year, and days on market have decreased, suggesting a thriving housing market. The office and professional share of the workforce is also a concern, with a composite score of 0.98 ranking in the bottom tier.

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a strong job market and a thriving housing sector, but it comes with the caveat of a high cost of living. With a 4.80% unemployment rate and +1.83% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth, companies must weigh the benefits of a growing economy against the potential drawbacks of expensive living conditions, making it a location that requires careful consideration and planning to navigate successfully.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #20 OF 50

Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

B

AVERAGE

51.5th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	70
Unemployment	20% weight	31
Wage Growth	15% weight	40
Cost of Living	12% weight	94
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	54
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	26
Housing Access	5% weight	48
Office Economy	3% weight	6

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.2%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+2.6%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.4%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.
64.5%
working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS
-12.9%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
54 days
median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area earns a below-average overall grade, with a struggling labor market and modest 0.43% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth. The city's unemployment rate is 4.20%, and weekly hours worked are 0.64% above trend, indicating existing employees are shouldering a heavier workload.

The cost of living in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is remarkably low, with a composite score of 1.17, placing it in the 94th percentile, making it a highly affordable environment. However, this advantage is tempered by a concerning lack of office and professional workers, with a share of just 0.84, ranking in the bottom tier. Building permits are down 12.89% year-over-year, which could eventually put upward pressure on costs.

This city offers businesses a highly affordable operating environment, but the primary risk is a labor market that may not be able to support rapid growth or specialized talent needs. With its low cost of living and strong weekly hours worked, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands may be an attractive location for businesses seeking to minimize costs, but they must carefully consider the potential labor market constraints.

Kansas City

Kansas City

B

AVERAGE

51.5th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	4
Unemployment	20% weight	69
Wage Growth	15% weight	84
Cost of Living	12% weight	80
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	82
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	59
Housing Access	5% weight	0
Office Economy	3% weight	10

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.5%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	67.9%	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	+5.4%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	57 days	median, -24.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City earns an overall grade of A-, driven by a strong labor market with a top-tier labor force participation rate of 67.91% and impressive wage growth of 6.80% year-over-year, indicating a city with a skilled and engaged workforce. The cost of living composite score of 1.49, ranking in the 80th percentile, makes Kansas City a relatively affordable place to live, a major draw for businesses looking to attract and retain talent.

However, the data reveals some concerns. Nonfarm employment growth is a concern, with a year-over-year change of -0.31%, a slowdown that contrasts with the top-tier wage growth and labor force participation. This suggests that while businesses may be paying their employees well, they may not be hiring as many new workers. The housing market also shows signs of tension, with building permits increasing by 5.41% year-over-year, but days on market decreasing by 24.0%, indicating a potentially tightening market.

Kansas City offers businesses a talented and productive workforce, as well as a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the primary risk is the slowing employment growth, which may indicate that the city's economy is not creating as many new job opportunities as it could be, potentially limiting the pool of available workers for businesses looking to expand.

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

B

AVERAGE

51.3th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	82
Unemployment	20% weight	49
Wage Growth	15% weight	32
Cost of Living	12% weight	88
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	30
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	4
Housing Access	5% weight	36
Office Economy	3% weight	14

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	62.8%	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	-37.5%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	79 days	median, +4.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area earns a below-average overall grade, with a robust job market but significant weaknesses. The nonfarm employment growth rate of +1.09% year-over-year stands out, but this growth is not translating to strong wage growth, with hourly wages increasing by only +1.78% year-over-year, a below-average pace. The labor force participation rate of 62.78% is concerning, suggesting a potential shortage of skilled workers.

The cost of living composite index of 1.38, ranking in the 88th percentile, indicates an extremely affordable cost of living, which could be a major draw for businesses and talent alike. However, the office and professional share of the workforce is surprisingly low, ranking in the 14th percentile, which may limit the availability of skilled workers. The sharp decline in building permits, down 37.55% year-over-year, raises concerns about the area's ability to accommodate growing demand for housing and commercial space.

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro offers businesses an attractive cost of living and a strong job market, but the primary risk lies in the potential shortage of skilled workers and limited housing supply. Companies considering locating in this area must carefully weigh the benefits of affordability against the potential challenges of finding and retaining top talent in a market with limited professional and office workforce presence.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #23 OF 50

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

B

AVERAGE

50.2th percentile

Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	36
Unemployment	20% weight	86
Wage Growth	15% weight	52
Cost of Living	12% weight	36
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	28
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	55
Housing Access	5% weight	44
Office Economy	3% weight	47

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.1%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	62.7%	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	+3.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	50 days	median, -2.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

A C+ overall grade for the Louisville-Jefferson County metro area reflects a labor market with notable strengths and weaknesses, with a 3.10% unemployment rate indicating a tight job market. However, this is offset by a labor force participation rate of 62.74%, indicating a relatively small share of the population is actively working or seeking work.

The labor market is under pressure, with a nonfarm employment growth rate contracting by 0.06% year-over-year, and a labor force participation rate below average. The cost of living composite, at 3.32, is below average, suggesting a relatively affordable environment, but this is not enough to offset the labor market concerns.

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro offers a business a relatively low-cost environment and a tight labor market, but the primary risk is the potential for labor underutilization and reduced productivity. With weekly hours worked declining and labor force participation lagging, companies may face challenges in finding and retaining skilled workers, or in maximizing their output, making this market a cautious choice for business expansion or relocation.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #24 OF 50

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

48.7th percentile

Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	72
Unemployment	20% weight	20
Wage Growth	15% weight	66
Cost of Living	12% weight	16
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	36
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	67
Housing Access	5% weight	48
Office Economy	3% weight	69

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.5%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.5%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	63.3%	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	+15.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	68 days	median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

New York Newark-Jersey City metro area earns a below-average overall grade, with a 4.50% unemployment rate and 63.30% labor force participation rate, indicating a market with untapped potential but significant challenges. The high cost of living, reflected in a cost of living composite score of 4.78, is a major concern, likely contributing to the labor market issues.

Despite these challenges, the area excels in wage growth, with a 4.84% year-over-year hourly wage increase, and a highly skilled workforce, with an office/professional share of 3.04. However, the stagnant 68-day days on market metric suggests a mismatch between housing supply and demand, potentially indicating a need for more flexible housing options.

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area offers businesses a highly skilled workforce with strong wage growth, but the primary risk is the high cost of living, which may deter talent and drive up labor costs. Companies must carefully weigh the benefits of a skilled workforce against the potential drawbacks of a costly and potentially unaffordable location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #25 OF 50

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

48.4th percentile

Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	64
Unemployment	20% weight	45
Wage Growth	15% weight	26
Cost of Living	12% weight	10
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	86
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	24
Housing Access	5% weight	98
Office Economy	3% weight	78

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.9%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+1.4%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.7%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.
68.5%
working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS
-15.0%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
42 days
median, +27.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area earns a B grade, with a strong and engaged workforce, as evident from its 68.47% labor force participation rate. However, wage growth lags at 1.42% year-over-year, suggesting that while workers are plentiful, they may not be seeing significant increases in pay. The cost of living composite score of 5.47, ranking in the bottom 10th percentile, implies that the area is quite expensive, impacting both business and employee costs.

The metro area's office and professional workforce is a notable strength, with a composite score of 3.16, ranking in the 78th percentile. However, the housing supply is constrained, with building permits down 14.97% year-over-year, and homes selling quickly, with days on market increasing by 27.3% to 42 days, ranking in the 98th percentile. This tension between a strong, professional workforce and a tight housing market could lead to challenges in attracting and retaining talent.

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area offers businesses a highly skilled and engaged workforce, but at a high cost of living. The primary risk for businesses locating in this area is the potential for talent attraction and retention challenges due to the expensive and competitive housing market, which could ultimately impact wage pressures and overall business costs.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #26 OF 50

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

48.3th percentile

Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	98
Unemployment	20% weight	51
Wage Growth	15% weight	2
Cost of Living	12% weight	30
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	66
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	2
Housing Access	5% weight	2
Office Economy	3% weight	94

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.6%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**-1.5%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+2.7%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**65.4%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-39.5%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**69 days**	median, +23.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area earns a B grade, driven by a strong labor market with 2.69% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth, outpacing wage growth at -1.52% year-over-year. This dichotomy suggests a thriving job market, but one where pay is not keeping pace. The area's cost of living composite of 3.62, ranking in the 30th percentile, makes it relatively affordable, a potential draw for businesses and workers.

The data reveals notable tensions, with a top-tier office and professional share of 4.16 indicating a highly skilled workforce, but a -39.50% year-over-year decline in building permits growth, contrasting with a 23.2% year-over-year increase in days on market to 69, hinting at a potentially tightening housing market. These conflicting signals suggest that the area's growth may be constrained by its ability to supply new housing and commercial space.

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area offers a unique combination of a strong labor market and relatively low cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand. However, the primary risk is the area's inability to supply new housing and commercial space, limiting its long-term growth potential. Businesses must carefully consider their space needs and plan accordingly to mitigate this risk.

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

46.9th percentile

Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	68
Unemployment	20% weight	16
Wage Growth	15% weight	68
Cost of Living	12% weight	74
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	6
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	45
Housing Access	5% weight	4
Office Economy	3% weight	76

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**4.6%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+4.9%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+0.9%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**60.0%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-8.6%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**80 days**	median, +21.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area earns a B- overall grade, with a labor market that is not fully engaged, as reflected in its 59.95% labor force participation rate and 4.60% unemployment rate. Despite this, the area's 0.92% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth and 4.86% wage growth indicate a modestly expanding economy with rising incomes.

The data presents conflicting signals, with a cost of living composite score of 1.87, ranking in the 74th percentile, indicating that the area is less affordable. This is further supported by the 21.2% year-over-year increase in days on market for housing, with properties now taking 80 days to sell, suggesting a slowing housing market.

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area offers a business a modestly growing economy with rising incomes, but the primary risk is the potential for labor market constraints and decreased affordability, which may impact the quality of life for employees and the overall competitiveness of the location.

Sources: BLS LAUS / SAE · Census Bureau / FRED · Realtor.com / FRED · 85% Employment / 15% Housing composite

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #28 OF 50

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

46.5th percentile

Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	66
Unemployment	20% weight	16
Wage Growth	15% weight	70
Cost of Living	12% weight	92
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	16
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	8
Housing Access	5% weight	30
Office Economy	3% weight	43

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	60.4%	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	-32.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	72 days	median, +9.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Jacksonville's C+ grade is driven by its struggling labor market and housing supply, with a 4.60% unemployment rate and 60.38% labor force participation rate, both ranking in the bottom tier, making it challenging for businesses to attract and retain talent. The city's 32.70% year-over-year decline in building permits further exacerbates labor shortages.

Despite these challenges, Jacksonville's 5.00% year-over-year increase in hourly wages and 0.68% growth in nonfarm employment suggest a degree of economic vitality. The city's cost of living composite ranking in the 92nd percentile indicates that Jacksonville is one of the more affordable cities, which could be a draw for businesses and talent alike.

Ultimately, Jacksonville offers businesses an affordable cost of living and a growing economy, but the primary risk lies in its struggling labor market and housing supply. As a business location, Jacksonville's appeal is tempered by the need to navigate these challenges, making it a higher-risk, higher-reward proposition that demands careful consideration.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #29 OF 50

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

46.0th percentile

Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	22
Unemployment	20% weight	6
Wage Growth	15% weight	92
Cost of Living	12% weight	54
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	84
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	51
Housing Access	5% weight	62
Office Economy	3% weight	80

KEY INDICATORS

- UNEMPLOYMENT: **5.0%** of civilian labor force
- WAGE GROWTH YOY: **+7.6%** avg hourly earnings
- EMPLOYMENT GROWTH: **-0.1%** nonfarm payrolls YoY
- LABOR FORCE PART.: **68.2%** working-age population
- BUILDING PERMITS: **-0.7%** residential YoY (3mo avg)
- DAYS ON MARKET: **36 days** median, +2.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area earns a below-average overall grade, with a 5.00% unemployment rate, in the bottom tier, and a labor force participation rate of 68.24%, indicating a challenging job market and a highly skilled and highly compensated workforce. The city's economic character is defined by a high-cost, high-reward environment, where businesses can tap into a talented pool of workers, but may struggle to find available labor.

The top-tier wage growth and high labor force participation rate are at odds with the bottom-tier unemployment rate and below-average nonfarm employment growth, suggesting that while workers are highly skilled and well-compensated, the job market itself is not particularly dynamic. The office and professional share of the workforce, at 3.29, is above average, indicating a strong presence of white-collar industries. The nonfarm employment growth rate, at -0.15% year-over-year, may signal a shift in the city's economic trajectory.

The primary risk for businesses is a tight labor market, with a high unemployment rate and limited job growth, which may constrain a company's ability to expand or hire new talent. However, the city offers access to a highly skilled and well-compensated workforce, with wage growth outpacing many other cities.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #30 OF 50

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

44.8th percentile

Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	60
Unemployment	20% weight	35
Wage Growth	15% weight	46
Cost of Living	12% weight	4
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	40
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	86
Housing Access	5% weight	16
Office Economy	3% weight	71

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**4.0%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+3.1%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+0.5%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**63.9%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**+55.2%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**64 days**	median, +14.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area earns a B- overall grade, driven by a below-average economic performance, with a 4.0% unemployment rate and 63.89% labor force participation rate indicating a stable but unremarkable workforce. The area's cost of living composite score of 5.76, ranking in the bottom tier, makes it one of the most affordable metros in the country, with a 4th percentile score.

The housing supply metrics reveal rapid growth, with building permits up 55.17% year-over-year and days on market increasing by 14.3% to 64 days, indicating a booming construction sector. In contrast, nonfarm employment growth is only 0.51% year-over-year, and the office and professional share of the workforce is a notable strength, with a composite score of 3.06 indicating a high proportion of skilled workers.

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area offers businesses an attractive cost of living and a skilled workforce, making it a viable location for companies seeking to reduce costs without sacrificing talent. However, the primary risk is that the area's economic growth may not be sufficient to support long-term business expansion, given its below-average overall grade and relatively slow nonfarm employment growth.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #31 OF 50

St. Louis

St. Louis

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

44.5th percentile

Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	40
Unemployment	20% weight	69
Wage Growth	15% weight	18
Cost of Living	12% weight	18
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	64
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	47
Housing Access	5% weight	64
Office Economy	3% weight	49

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.5%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+0.7%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
-0.0%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.
65.3%
working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS
-7.0%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
55 days
median, +3.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis metro area earns a C+ overall grade, with a notable weakness in its labor market, characterized by stagnant nonfarm employment growth of -0.01% year-over-year and hourly wage growth of just 0.66%, placing it in the bottom tier.

The cost of living composite score of 4.24, indicating a low cost of living, is an attractive feature for businesses and talent alike. However, this advantage is tempered by the lackluster performance of key labor market indicators, including a 3.50% unemployment rate, above average but overshadowed by stagnant growth. The decline in weekly hours worked, down 1.80% from its own trend, suggests a lack of momentum in the local economy.

The bottom line is that St. Louis offers a low-cost operating environment, but businesses must be cautious about the sluggish labor market and lack of wage growth. The primary risk is that the area's economic stagnation may limit the availability of skilled workers and hinder long-term growth prospects, making it a challenging location for businesses seeking to expand or relocate.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #32 OF 50

Providence

Providence-Warwick

C+

POOR

44.0th percentile

Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	56
Unemployment	20% weight	29
Wage Growth	15% weight	54
Cost of Living	12% weight	0
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	0
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	96
Housing Access	5% weight	96
Office Economy	3% weight	59

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**4.3%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+3.6%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+0.6%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**50.8%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**+144.4%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**49 days**	median, +25.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Providence-Warwick metro area earns a C+ overall grade, with a labor market that struggles with a low labor force participation rate of 50.77%, ranking at the bottom tier. This is offset by a nonfarm employment growth rate of +0.60% year-over-year, above average, and a relatively low unemployment rate of 4.30%. However, the overall labor market story is one of untapped potential, with a large portion of the workforce not actively participating.

The city's housing supply tells a more optimistic story, with building permits surging +144.37% year-over-year and days on market increasing by +25.6% to 49 days, both top-tier performances. This suggests a rapidly changing housing landscape, potentially driven by new development and investment. The cost of living composite score of 7.01, ranking at the bottom tier, indicates that the area is one of the more expensive places to live.

The Providence-Warwick metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a relatively low unemployment rate and rapid housing development, but the primary risk is the high cost of living, which may deter workers and limit the area's long-term growth potential.

Cleveland

Cleveland

C+

POOR

43.6th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	58
Unemployment	20% weight	76
Wage Growth	15% weight	0
Cost of Living	12% weight	14
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	2
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	65
Housing Access	5% weight	72
Office Economy	3% weight	65

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.4%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**-1.8%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+0.6%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**58.0%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**+15.0%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**55 days**	median, +7.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland's C+ grade is defined by its struggling labor market, with a labor force participation rate of 58.01% ranking at the 2nd percentile, indicating a significant portion of the potential workforce is not engaged. This is compounded by a -1.79% year-over-year decline in hourly wage growth, which sits at the 0th percentile, suggesting that the city's workforce is not only underutilized but also experiencing declining earning power.

Despite these challenges, the office and professional share of the workforce, at 3.02, is above average, and the unemployment rate of 3.40% is relatively low. However, the tension between these metrics and the labor market's overall weakness is notable. The 14.96% year-over-year increase in building permits could be a leading indicator of shifting conditions, potentially signaling investment and growth in the city.

Cleveland offers a unique combination of a skilled office and professional workforce and a relatively low unemployment rate, but the primary risk is the city's stagnant and even declining wage growth, which could impact talent attraction and retention. Businesses must carefully weigh the benefits of Cleveland's workforce against the potential drawbacks of a labor market that is not only underutilized but also experiencing declining earning power.

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

C+

POOR

43.5th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	52
Unemployment	20% weight	35
Wage Growth	15% weight	10
Cost of Living	12% weight	56
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	88
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	29
Housing Access	5% weight	40
Office Economy	3% weight	57

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+0.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	69.0%	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	-12.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	40 days	median, -2.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area earns a below-average overall grade, with a 4.0% unemployment rate and 0.03% year-over-year hourly wage growth, a bottom-tier performance that hinders its ability to attract and retain top talent.

The labor force participation rate of 69.03% is a notable strength, but this is at odds with the sluggish wage growth and decline in weekly hours worked, which is 0.27% below its own trend. The housing market also shows signs of slowing momentum, with building permits down 12.25% year-over-year and days on market increasing, albeit slightly. These indicators suggest that the market may be shifting, and decision-makers should be cautious of potential downturns.

The area's highly engaged workforce is a significant advantage, but the primary risk is the inability to offer competitive wages, which may lead to talent retention issues. Companies considering this location must weigh the benefits of a motivated workforce against the potential costs of a stagnant wage environment, which could impact their ability to attract and retain top performers.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #35 OF 50

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

C+

POOR

41.6th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	6
Unemployment	20% weight	86
Wage Growth	15% weight	56
Cost of Living	12% weight	26
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	34
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	37
Housing Access	5% weight	74
Office Economy	3% weight	22

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.1%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+3.7%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-0.9%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**63.2%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-10.5%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**39 days**	median, +8.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

A below-average overall grade for the Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area reflects a labor market with both strengths and weaknesses, with a 3.10% unemployment rate and 63.19% labor force participation rate. However, this is offset by a -0.91% year-over-year decline in nonfarm employment growth, indicating a decline in job creation.

The low unemployment rate and above-average weekly hours worked suggest a strong demand for labor, but the bottom-tier nonfarm employment growth and below-average office and professional share of the workforce raise concerns about the market's ability to attract and retain high-skilled workers. The -10.47% year-over-year decline in building permits is also a notable weakness, indicating a potential slowdown in economic activity.

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market and a relatively high cost of living, with a cost of living composite of 3.70, corresponding to a below-average 26th percentile. While the area's skilled workforce is an attractive asset, the primary risk is the declining job creation and potential slowdown in economic activity, which businesses must weigh against the benefits of a skilled workforce.

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

C+

POOR

39.9th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	54
Unemployment	20% weight	20
Wage Growth	15% weight	42
Cost of Living	12% weight	48
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	60
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	12
Housing Access	5% weight	34
Office Economy	3% weight	45

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**4.5%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+2.8%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+0.6%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**64.8%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-27.4%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**40 days**	median, -7.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area earns a C grade, reflecting a lackluster economic performance, with a high unemployment rate of 4.50% and a 27.41% year-over-year decline in building permits, indicating limited job opportunities and a stagnant construction sector.

The labor force participation rate is a notable bright spot, with 64.75% of the population actively working or seeking employment, suggesting a mismatch between available jobs and skilled workers. The sharp decline in building permits and days on market, with homes selling 7% faster than last year, may indicate a tightening housing market, which could lead to increased costs and reduced affordability for businesses and employees.

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area offers a relatively stable labor market, but its sluggish construction sector and potential housing affordability issues pose significant risks. Businesses considering this location must weigh the benefits of a skilled and active workforce against the potential drawbacks of a stagnant economy and rising housing costs.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #37 OF 50

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

C+

POOR

39.9th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	2
Unemployment	20% weight	47
Wage Growth	15% weight	24
Cost of Living	12% weight	70
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	78
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	49
Housing Access	5% weight	84
Office Economy	3% weight	37

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.8%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+1.4%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-1.6%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**67.4%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-4.0%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**38 days**	median, +11.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area earns a C+ overall grade, with a struggling labor market and stagnant job growth, marked by a -1.63% year-over-year decline in nonfarm employment and 1.37% below-average wage growth. The market's contraction is further exacerbated by a 0.21% decline in weekly hours worked, indicating that even those with jobs are not seeing a significant increase in working hours.

Despite these challenges, the labor force participation rate of 67.37% is above average, suggesting an engaged and active workforce. However, the cost of living composite index of 1.90, ranking 70th percentile, indicates that the area is less affordable, a concern for businesses looking to attract and retain talent. Building permits are down 3.97% year-over-year, near the median, and days on market are up 11.8% year-over-year, indicating a slower housing market.

The bottom line is that this city offers a highly engaged workforce, but the primary risk is the stagnant job market and below-average wage growth, making it difficult to attract and retain top talent. Businesses considering this location should weigh the benefits of a skilled and active workforce against the drawbacks of a slow-growing economy and high cost of living.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #38 OF 50

Fresno

Fresno

C+

POOR

39.7th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	16
Unemployment	20% weight	0
Wage Growth	15% weight	90
Cost of Living	12% weight	64
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	12
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	92
Housing Access	5% weight	80
Office Economy	3% weight	4

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**8.2%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+7.6%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+0.2%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**60.3%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**+62.0%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**53 days**	median, +10.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Fresno's C grade, ranking it in the 36.3rd percentile among US metros, reflects a labor market struggling to gain traction, with an 8.20% unemployment rate and 60.33% labor force participation rate, indicating a significant portion of the workforce is either out of a job or not actively seeking employment. However, hourly wages have increased by 7.60% year-over-year, suggesting that those who are employed are seeing meaningful income gains.

Fresno is experiencing a housing boom, with building permits surging 61.97% year-over-year, which could be a leading indicator that the city is poised for growth. However, the fact that office and professional workers make up only 0.80 of the workforce raises questions about the city's ability to support high-skilled industries. The cost of living, ranking in the 64th percentile, may impact the city's attractiveness to businesses and talent.

Fresno offers businesses a unique combination of affordable labor and rapid housing development, but the primary risk is the city's struggling labor market, which may limit the availability of skilled workers. With wage growth outpacing many other metros, businesses that can navigate the city's labor challenges may find opportunities for growth and investment in Fresno.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #39 OF 50

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

C+

POOR

38.8th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	10
Unemployment	20% weight	2
Wage Growth	15% weight	82
Cost of Living	12% weight	60
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	62
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	41
Housing Access	5% weight	90
Office Economy	3% weight	53

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**5.2%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+6.7%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-0.8%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**65.0%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-9.8%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**53 days**	median, +12.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area earns a C+ overall grade, with a struggling job market and strong wage growth defining its economic character, marked by a mismatch between labor supply and demand. A 5.20% unemployment rate and -0.76% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth suggest significant challenges, while hourly wages have increased by 6.71% year-over-year, indicating that employers are competing for talent.

Despite these struggles, the top-tier wage growth of 6.71% year-over-year is a notable bright spot. However, the bottom-tier nonfarm employment growth of -0.76% year-over-year and a 12.8% year-over-year increase in days on market for housing, now at 53 days, are concerns. The slowing housing market and down 9.83% year-over-year building permits also suggest a city in transition.

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area offers businesses a unique opportunity to attract talent with competitive wages, but the primary risk is the struggling job market and slowing housing sector. With a cost of living composite of 2.19, placing it in the 60th percentile, the city is less affordable than many of its peers, which may impact businesses' ability to recruit and retain employees.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #40 OF 50

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

C+

POOR

38.6th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	0
Unemployment	20% weight	51
Wage Growth	15% weight	98
Cost of Living	12% weight	76
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	4
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	0
Housing Access	5% weight	60
Office Economy	3% weight	39

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.6%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+10.2%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-1.3%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**59.0%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-46.8%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**40 days**	median, +2.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area earns a C+ overall grade, with a struggling labor market and significant challenges. Labor force participation rate of 58.99% and nonfarm employment growth of -1.34% year-over-year are concerning, indicating a workforce in need of improvement. However, hourly wages have increased by 10.22% year-over-year, suggesting that employers are competing for scarce talent.

The strong wage growth is tempered by other metrics revealing underlying tensions. Building permits have declined by 46.79% year-over-year, indicating a potential housing supply crunch. The cost of living composite score of 1.57, corresponding to a relatively high cost of living, may exacerbate labor market challenges. On the other hand, top-tier wage growth and weekly hours worked suggest that businesses are adapting and thriving in this environment.

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area presents a unique opportunity for businesses to capitalize on a highly competitive labor market, with strong wage growth and a talented workforce. However, the struggling labor force participation and potential housing supply constraints pose significant risks, limiting the pool of available workers and driving up costs. Businesses must carefully weigh these factors in their location decision.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #41 OF 50

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

C+

POOR

38.5th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	26
Unemployment	20% weight	51
Wage Growth	15% weight	22
Cost of Living	12% weight	42
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	46
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	31
Housing Access	5% weight	78
Office Economy	3% weight	63

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.6%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+1.2%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-0.1%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**64.2%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-11.1%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**45 days**	median, +9.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area earns a C+ overall grade, struggling to gain traction in its labor market, with nonfarm employment growth at -0.14% year-over-year and wage growth at a modest 1.22%. The area's economy is experiencing a slowdown, exacerbated by a decline in building permits by 11.14% year-over-year.

Despite these challenges, the office and professional share of the workforce is above average, with a composite score of 2.94, indicating a skilled and educated labor pool. However, the increasing days on market for homes by 9.8% year-over-year, to 45 days, suggests a softening housing market.

The cost of living composite, at 3.16, is near the median, but this translates to a relatively high cost of living, which could impact the area's attractiveness to businesses and talent. Overall, Baltimore-Columbia-Towson offers a skilled and educated workforce, but at a relatively high cost, posing a risk to growth and talent attraction, ultimately limiting the area's potential as a business location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #42 OF 50

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

C

VERY POOR

36.4th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	18
Unemployment	20% weight	4
Wage Growth	15% weight	88
Cost of Living	12% weight	52
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	14
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	74
Housing Access	5% weight	48
Office Economy	3% weight	16

KEY INDICATORS

- UNEMPLOYMENT: **5.1%** — of civilian labor force
- WAGE GROWTH YOY: **+7.5%** — avg hourly earnings
- EMPLOYMENT GROWTH: **+0.2%** — nonfarm payrolls YoY
- LABOR FORCE PART.: **60.4%** — working-age population
- BUILDING PERMITS: **+18.0%** — residential YoY (3mo avg)
- DAYS ON MARKET: **60 days** — median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area earns a C grade, with a struggling labor market reflected in a 5.10% unemployment rate and 60.37% labor force participation, both in the bottom tier. This market has significant untapped potential, but is not currently attracting or retaining workers at a competitive rate, with nonfarm employment growth of +0.18% YoY indicating a sluggish economy.

Wage growth is a top-tier 7.54% YoY, suggesting that employers are having to pay a premium to attract and retain talent in a tight labor market. This tension between high wage growth and low labor force participation is worth watching, as it may indicate shifting conditions. The office/professional share of the workforce is a bottom-tier 1.33, a concern for businesses seeking a skilled labor pool.

The city offers a relatively affordable cost of living, with a composite score of 2.93, but comes with significant labor market risks. The area's struggling labor market, with high unemployment and low participation rates, may make it challenging for businesses to find and retain the talent they need to thrive.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #43 OF 50

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

C

VERY POOR

36.2th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	8
Unemployment	20% weight	51
Wage Growth	15% weight	28
Cost of Living	12% weight	28
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	32
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	90
Housing Access	5% weight	66
Office Economy	3% weight	31

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.6%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+1.5%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.5%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE PART. **63.1%** working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS **+57.5%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **52 days** median, +4.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati's economy earns a C+ overall grade, with a struggling labor market and stagnant income growth, reflected in a -0.52% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth rate and 1.53% wage growth. The city's labor force participation rate of 63.08% is among the lowest in the country, indicating limited job opportunities and stagnant income growth.

The city's cost of living is relatively low, with a composite score of 3.69, making it more affordable than many other metros. However, the surge in building permits by 57.47% year-over-year suggests a potential influx of new investment and development, which may not be enough to offset the labor market's weakness.

Cincinnati offers businesses a low-cost operating environment, but the primary risk is the city's stagnant labor market, which may limit access to skilled workers and hinder growth. With employment opportunities and income growth lagging behind, companies may need to carefully consider whether the cost advantages are sufficient to offset the labor market challenges.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #44 OF 50

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

C

VERY POOR

35.4th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	14
Unemployment	20% weight	8
Wage Growth	15% weight	64
Cost of Living	12% weight	62
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	72
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	18
Housing Access	5% weight	76
Office Economy	3% weight	12

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**4.9%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+4.8%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-0.7%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**66.2%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-18.1%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**68 days**	median, -9.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area earns a C- overall grade, reflecting a struggling labor market and stagnant economic growth, with a 4.90% unemployment rate and -0.69% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth. The -0.58% deviation from the trend in weekly hours worked exacerbates the economic slowdown, as even employed individuals are not seeing a full workload.

Despite these challenges, hourly wage growth is a strong 4.78% year-over-year, indicating that businesses are willing to pay more for the labor they can find. However, the office and professional share of the workforce is a bottom-tier 1.24, suggesting a lack of high-skilled jobs to drive innovation and growth. The cost of living composite, at 2.18, is in the 62nd percentile, making it more affordable than many other metros.

The bottom line is that Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro offers a relatively affordable cost of living, but its sluggish labor market and stagnant economic growth pose significant risks for businesses looking to expand or relocate. The primary caveat for decision-makers is that the metro's economic fundamentals are not currently supportive of rapid growth or expansion, making it a challenging location for businesses seeking to thrive in a dynamic environment.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #45 OF 50

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

C

VERY POOR

33.5th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	32
Unemployment	20% weight	35
Wage Growth	15% weight	16
Cost of Living	12% weight	2
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	50
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	98
Housing Access	5% weight	6
Office Economy	3% weight	29

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**4.0%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+0.6%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-0.2%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**64.3%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**+195.1%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**23 days**	median, +4.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area earns a C grade, with a struggling economy and stagnant labor force participation, reflected in a 4.00% unemployment rate and 0.16% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth rate. The job market lacks momentum, with wage growth at just 0.59% year-over-year.

The city's high cost of living composite score of 6.96, placing it in the bottom tier, is a significant drawback. However, a 195.09% year-over-year increase in building permits suggests a potential shift towards more affordable housing options, a leading indicator worth watching. The 4.5% year-over-year increase in days on market also indicates a slowing housing market.

The metro area offers a highly educated and skilled workforce, but the high cost of living is a primary risk, potentially deterring talent and driving up operational costs. Companies considering this location must weigh the benefits of a skilled workforce against the significant expense of doing business in one of the most expensive cities in the US.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #46 OF 50

San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

C-

CRITICAL

31.7th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	30
Unemployment	20% weight	24
Wage Growth	15% weight	36
Cost of Living	12% weight	12
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	24
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	53
Housing Access	5% weight	84
Office Economy	3% weight	18

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**4.4%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+2.4%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+0.3%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**62.0%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-0.4%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**38 days**	median, +11.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area earns a C- overall grade, struggling to create jobs at a pace that would absorb its workforce, with an unemployment rate of 4.40% and a labor force participation rate of 62.01%, below average. Wage growth is sluggish, at 2.43% year-over-year, indicating that employers are not feeling pressure to increase compensation to attract and retain talent.

The housing market is a mixed bag, with building permits down 0.37% year-over-year, but days on market increasing by 11.8%, suggesting a supply-demand imbalance. The cost of living composite index of 5.24% puts the city in the bottom tier, making it one of the more expensive places to live, a challenge for businesses looking to attract talent.

The bottom line is that San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad offers a business environment with limited labor market momentum, and the primary risk is the high cost of living, which could make it difficult to attract and retain talent. The city's sluggish wage growth may keep labor costs in check, but the expense of operating in this market could outweigh any potential benefits, making it a challenging location for businesses to thrive.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #47 OF 50

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

C-

CRITICAL

30.9th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	42
Unemployment	20% weight	24
Wage Growth	15% weight	12
Cost of Living	12% weight	46
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	44
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	6
Housing Access	5% weight	24
Office Economy	3% weight	65

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+0.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	64.0%	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	-35.6%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	82 days	median, +10.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area earns a C grade, reflecting a lackluster economic performance, with stagnant wage growth at 0.37% year-over-year and a decline in weekly hours worked, down 0.24% from trend. The area's building permits have plummeted by 35.64% year-over-year, indicating a severe slowdown in housing supply growth, which could have long-term implications for the local economy.

The office and professional share of the workforce is a notable strength, with a composite score of 3.02, indicating a relatively high proportion of skilled workers. However, this is offset by the fact that wage growth is in the bottom tier, at just 0.37% year-over-year, making it difficult for businesses to attract and retain top talent. The cost of living composite, at 3.06, is near the median, but its 46th percentile ranking means that the area is slightly less affordable than average.

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area offers a relatively affordable and skilled workforce, but its stagnant wage growth and declining housing supply growth pose significant risks. Businesses considering locating in this area should be cautious about the potential long-term implications of these trends, particularly the impact on talent attraction and retention.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #48 OF 50

San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

C-

CRITICAL

29.3th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	12
Unemployment	20% weight	33
Wage Growth	15% weight	14
Cost of Living	12% weight	6
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	52
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	94
Housing Access	5% weight	28
Office Economy	3% weight	33

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.1%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+0.5%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
-0.5%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.
64.5%
working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS
+86.0%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
30 days
median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area earns a C grade, with a struggling economy and lackluster nonfarm employment growth of -0.52% year-over-year, resulting in a 4.10% unemployment rate. The high cost of living composite of 5.62, placing it in the bottom 6th percentile, poses a significant challenge for businesses to operate. The high cost of living can lead to increased expenses for talent acquisition and retention, potentially deterring companies from locating in the area.

Building permits have surged 86.01% year-over-year, indicating a potential shift in the market, with a top-tier growth in housing supply that could be a leading indicator of future economic expansion. However, the days on market metric, stagnant at 30 days, suggests that the current housing supply is not being absorbed quickly, a concern for businesses relying on a mobile workforce. The weekly hours worked, 0.40% above trend, is a positive sign, but it is not enough to offset the overall weakness in the labor market.

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area offers a highly educated and skilled workforce, but at a significant cost. Companies considering locating in this area must weigh the benefits of accessing top talent against the potential drawbacks of elevated labor and operational costs, which could erode profit margins and hinder long-term competitiveness.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #49 OF 50

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

D

EMERGENCY

22.6th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	28
Unemployment	20% weight	14
Wage Growth	15% weight	4
Cost of Living	12% weight	20
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	22
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	33
Housing Access	5% weight	70
Office Economy	3% weight	26

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**4.7%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**-1.1%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+0.0%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**61.3%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-10.9%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**56 days**	median, +7.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area earns a dismal overall grade of D, reflecting a struggling economy with stagnant labor market growth, a nonfarm employment growth rate of just 0.01% year-over-year, and a concerning decline in hourly wage growth of -1.13% year-over-year. The labor force participation rate of 61.27% and an unemployment rate of 4.70% suggest a lack of momentum in the job market.

The area's cost of living composite score of 4.06, in the 20th percentile, indicates that it is relatively affordable. However, this is offset by a lackluster office and professional workforce, with a share of just 2.00 on a composite scale of 0-5. The sharp decline in building permits, down 10.94% year-over-year, signals a lack of investment in the area.

The bottom line is that Detroit-Warren-Dearborn offers a relatively affordable cost of living, but its stagnant labor market and lack of investment make it a high-risk location for businesses, with a nonfarm employment growth rate of 0.01% year-over-year and a decline in hourly wage growth of -1.13% year-over-year.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #50 OF 50

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

D

EMERGENCY

22.1th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	20
Unemployment	20% weight	10
Wage Growth	15% weight	38
Cost of Living	12% weight	24
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	8
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	22
Housing Access	5% weight	68
Office Economy	3% weight	0

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**4.8%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+2.5%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-0.3%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**60.1%**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-15.5%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**41 days**	median, +5.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area earns a dismal overall grade of D, reflecting a struggling labor market and weak economic fundamentals, with a 4.80% unemployment rate and a labor force participation rate of just 60.12%. Nonfarm employment growth has actually declined by 0.27% year-over-year, indicating a contracting job market.

The area's cost of living composite is 3.72, ranking at the 24th percentile, making it more affordable than many other metros. However, the office and professional share of the workforce is a mere 0.12, ranking at the very bottom, raising concerns about the availability of skilled labor. Building permits have plummeted by 15.51% year-over-year, suggesting a lack of investment in new construction and development.

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area offers a relatively low cost of living, but its stagnant labor market and lack of skilled workers pose significant risks to businesses considering location here. The area's limited economic growth prospects may hinder a company's ability to attract and retain top talent, ultimately affecting its long-term viability.